ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

MUS 101: Fundamentals of Music Theory - Notation, Scales and Rhythm

Read, write and hear the basics before analysis

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Music | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

This pack covers staff notation, clefs, note values and metre, major and minor scales, intervals, triads, and the basics of African rhythmic organisation including polyrhythm and the standard pattern. It ends with an ear-training routine you can run without a piano.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Read and write notes on treble and bass staves.
- Construct major and minor scales and identify intervals.
- Build and identify triads.
- Describe polyrhythm and the standard pattern in African music.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Notation fundamentals

Notation is a tool for thought, not a substitute for hearing.

- Staff, clefs, ledger lines and the grand staff.
- Note values: whole, half, quarter, eighth, sixteenth and their rests.
- Dots and ties change duration, not pitch.
- Time signatures: simple, compound and irregular metre.
- Key signatures and the circle of fifths.
- Accidentals apply within the bar unless cancelled.

Scales, intervals and chords

Patterns make transposition manageable.

- Major scale pattern: tone-tone-semitone-tone-tone-tone-semitone.
- Natural, harmonic and melodic minor.
- Interval quality: major, minor, perfect, augmented, diminished.
- Triads: major, minor, diminished and augmented.
- Roman numeral analysis for progressions.
- Modes and pentatonic scales beyond the European common practice.

> **Sing what you write**
> If you cannot sing a scale or interval, you do not yet know it. Singing connects notation to hearing.

African rhythmic organisation

African music theory is not an appendix to European theory.

- The standard pattern (the 'short' bell pattern) as a timeline reference.
- Polyrhythm: simultaneous contrasting rhythmic layers.
- Cross-rhythm and the relationship of 3 against 2 or 12/8 feels.
- Call and response as a structural principle.
- Timeline instruments anchor ensemble coordination.
- Transcription is an interpretation; note your choices.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is the interval pattern of a major scale?

Answer: Tone, tone, semitone, tone, tone, tone, semitone.

2. How many semitones are in a perfect fifth?

Answer: Seven.

3. What is a triad?

Answer: A chord of three notes built in thirds from a root.

4. Define polyrhythm.

Answer: The simultaneous use of two or more contrasting rhythmic patterns that do not share a simple subdivision.

5. Why is the standard pattern important?

Answer: It functions as a timeline that anchors the ensemble and organises the cyclical structure of the music.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write out all major scales up to four sharps and flats.
- [ ] Practise reading treble and bass clefs daily for a week.
- [ ] Sing and identify ten intervals.
- [ ] Build major, minor and diminished triads on five roots.
- [ ] Clap a 3:2 polyrhythm steadily for a minute.
- [ ] Transcribe four bars of a recorded pattern.
- [ ] Test yourself with a short dictation.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: